Degas, C'est Moi

By David Ives

INTRODUCTION

Edgar Degas once explained his talent: "It's one thing to copy what one sees, but it's much better to draw what can only be seen in one's memory. It's a transformation during which the imagination collaborates with the memory . . . there your recollections and fantasies are freed from the tyranny exerted by nature."

Today, you'll be witness to Ed's transformation . . . from mild-mannered unemployed Nothing to a world-of-his-own creation in which he becomes Degas for the day.

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ED is asleep. An alarm clock goes off. He doesn't move. Then, he is suddenly awake.

ED: **(Pg 19-32)** A stroke of genius. I decide to be Degas for a day. Edgar Degas. Why Degas? says a pesky little voice at the back of my head. Well, why not Degas? Pourquoi, pas Degas? Maybe the prismatic bars of color on my ceiling have inspired me. Maybe the creamy white light spreading on my walls has moved me. Maybe it's all this cheap French wine I been drinking. *(He finds a wine bottle in his bed)* Anyway I don't have to explain myself Yes! Today, I will be Edgar Degas! -- Is it Edgar, or Edouard? Okay, so I don't know much about Degas. Let's see. 'Dead, French, impressionist painter of jockeys, ballerinas, flowers, that kinda thing. And okay granted, I'm not French, dead, or a painter of any kind. Not a lotta common ground. And yet, and yet -- are Degas and I not united by our shared humanity? By our common need for love, coffee, and deodorant? *(DORIS enters.)* Doris breaks in on my inspiration.

DORIS: Oh God, oh God, oh God. Have you seen my glasses? I can't find my glasses.

ED: Doris, I say to Doris, I'm going to be Degas today. Doris doesn't see the brilliance of the idea.

DORIS: This is a tragedy.

ED: Doris -- I am Degas!

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DORIS: You're what?

ED: Is it Edgar or Edward? It's Edgar, isn't it.

DORIS: Don't forget the dry cleaning. *(Doris kisses him.)* 'Bye. *(Doris exits.)*

ED: Alas, poor Doris. Distracted by the banal. No matter. I start my day and brush my teeth as Degas. *(Ed hops out of bed and produces a green toothbrush. The bed disappears.)* Oh man. This is wonderful! In the bathroom, everything seems transformed, yet nothing has changed. Will you look at the lustre of that toilet? And the light on that green plastic! The bristles are disgusting, but the light is fantastic! *(French accent)* Per'aps I wed paint you later. How did I become such a genius? I, who flunked woodshop in high school? Well, something must've happened. Because now I'm great. I'm brilliant. My name will live forever! *(He considers that a second)* Whoo. Wow. This is too big for even me to contemplate. I go out into the world with dry cleaning. *(He grabs some clothing as we hear city noises, car horns)* O, glorious polychromatic city! Gone the dreary daily deja vu. Today-Degas vu! At the dry cleaner's I notice something strange. . .

DRY CLEANER: *(taking the dry cleaning)* Jacket, one shirt, one skirt, one

ED: My dry cleaner acts exactly the same.

DRY CLEANER: You know you need some serious reweaving?

ED: Madam, how I would love to capture you in charcoal.

DRY CLEANER: My husband already caught me in puce. *(Tears a sheet off the pad.)* After five. *(exits with the clothing)*

ED: She gives not a flutter of recognition. Then on the corner, the newsguy tries to sell me my paper just like always.

NEWSGUY: Daily Noose?

ED: Actually, have you got anything en Jranfaise?

NEWSGUY: Let's see, I got Le Monde, Le Reve, La Chasse, and Mademoiselle Boom Boom.

ED: I'll just take the News.

NEWSGUY: Change. *(He flips an invisible coin, which Ed "catches," then the Newsguy exits)*

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ED: Still not a blink of recognition. Then as I head down Broadway, people pass me by without a second glance. I might as well be invisible. I, Edgar Degas! And then I realize with a shock: It makes no difference to be Degas. To all these people, I could be anyone! And yet. . . And yet maybe the other Degas walked this invisibly through Paris. *(We hear a French accordion and the clip-clop if horses)* Maybe he too was rudely bumped into by the bourgeoisie on the upper Left Bank. . . And you know, there's a kind of comfort in this. Completely anonymous, I'm free to appreciate the gray cloud of pigeons overhead. . . The impasto at Ray's Pizza. . . Nobody knows it, but I am walking down this street with a jewel cupped in my hands. The secret precious jewel of my talent.

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: Next!

ED: My delicious anonymity continues at Unemployment.

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: Sign your claim at the bottom, please.

ED: Do you notice the name I signed in the bottom right corner?

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: Edgar Day-hass. Edgar Deejis. Edgar De Gas. Edgar De What?

ED: Edgar Degas. And-?

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: And -- this name at the bottom does not match the name at the top of the form.

ED: No, no, no, no . . .

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: Are you not the same person as the person at the top of the form?

ED: I am a person at the top of my form. I am Edgar. Degas.

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER: The dead French painter?

ED: The same.

UNEMPLOYMENT WORKER Next!

ED: Oh -- the library. Maybe I should look myself up.

LIBRARIAN: Shhhhhh!

ED: Excuse me. Have you got anything on Degas?

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LIBRARIAN: Degas. You mean the crassly conservative counterfeminist patriarchal pedophile painter?

ED: No, I mean the colorist who chronicled his age and who continues to inspire through countless posters, postcards and T-shirts.

LIBRARIAN: Section D, aisle two.

ED: Patriarchal pedoph . . .

LIBRARIANQUIET! *(Librarian exits)*

ED: But who needs the carping of critics, the lies of biographers? I know who I am. Famished by creativity, I stop at Twin Donut. *(Two tables appear. A YOUNG WOMAN sits at one, writing in a journal. Ed sits at the other)* So there I am, scribbling a priceless doodle on my napkin, when I notice someone staring at me. A young woman writing in a journal. Has she recognized me? She smiles slightly. Yes. She knows I am Degas. Not only that. She loves Degas. That one look has redeemed all my years of effort. My work has given meaning to someone's life. *(A schmaltzy-romantic violin is heard)*

YOUNG WOMAN: *(writing)* "April six. Twin Donut. Just saw Edgar Degas two tables over. So he likes vanilla crullers too! Suddenly this day is glorious and memorable. Would love to lie in bed all afternoon and make l' amour with Degas. . ."

ED: But no. I'd only cast her off, break her heart. Not to mention what it would do to Doris. But isn't it my duty as an artist to experience life to the fullest. . . ?

YOUNG WOMAN: *(writing)* "Dwayne would kill me."

ED: Too late. Whoa, whoa, whoa, just for a picosecond there, I forget who I am! Just for a moment -- I seem to be nobody. The labor of hanging onto one's identity! At the museum I am simply amazed to find how much I accomplished -- even without television. (*A Degas self-portrait appears)* What's this. . . Ah. A self-portrait. Not a great likeness, maybe. But so full of. . . what? . . . feeling. I stare into my fathomless eyes. *(A MUSEUM GOER stands beside him looking at the portrait)*

MUSEUM GOER: Mmm. Bit smudgy, isn't it?

ED: "Smudgy"?

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MUSEUM GOER: This area in here.

ED: Yeah, but what about this area over here?

MUSEUM GOER: No, but look at this area here. This is smudge.

ED: Okay. So I had an off day.

MUSEUM GOER: An "off day" . . . ?

ED: Not all my work was perfect. Philistine. Probably headed for van Gogh. To kneel in adoration at the sunflowers. I couldn't believe it, the day he started signing his paintings "Vincent." "Vince," we called him. What a jerk.

Ah yes. Woman with Chrysanthemums. A personal favorite among my masterworks. God, when I remember that morning over a century ago. . . Can it be that long now? This was an empty canvas and I stood in front it paralyzed by its whiteness. Then I reached for my brush. . . He produces a paintbrush. . . . and the picture crystallized. In a moment I saw it all. This pensive woman, oblivious of the transcendent burst of color right at her shoulder. The natural exuberance of the flowers alongside her human sorrow. Yes. Yes! Our blindness to the beautiful! Our insensibility to the splendor right there within our reach!

MUSEUM GUARD: Step back, please.

ED: Excuse me?

MUSEUM GUARD: The painting. You have to step back, sir. You're too close to

ED: I'm too dose to this painting. . . ?

MUSEUM GUARD: Do you copy?

ED: No, I don't copy. I am an original! I step back. *(Guard exits)* But the glow of my exaltation stays with me all the way to the Akropolis Diner. . . where Doris meets me for dinner.

DORIS: What a day.

ED: What a fabulous day. Epic!

DORIS: Six hours of xeroxing.

ED: No, listen. Degas. Remember? I've been Degas all day.

DORIS: The toilets erupted again. The women's room was like Vesuvius.

ED: I am Degas.

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DORIS: They were going to fix those toilets last week.

ED: As Doris dilates on toilets, I begin to feel Degas slip away a little. . . like a second skin I'm shedding. . . leaving nothing behind.

People say they have a voice inside their heads. The voice that tells themselves the story of their lives. I too have always had a voice like that in my head. But now, tonight, no one is listening. The story of my life is going on unwatched. Unheard. I am alone. I find myself upstairs, sprawled on the bed while Doris runs the bathwater. Degas is dust. All my glory, all my fame, all my achievements are utterly forgotten. Immortality? A cruel joke. Then I find myself looking through the doorway into the bathroom and I see Doris standing with her foot up on the edge of the old lion-footed tub, drying herself. The overhead light is dim, but Doris is fluorescent-radiant-luminous-with pinks and lavenders and vermilions playing over her skin. The frayed towel she's wrapped in gleams like a rose. She turns and looks back at me and smiles.

Degas? Who needs him?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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